We were there, Differently

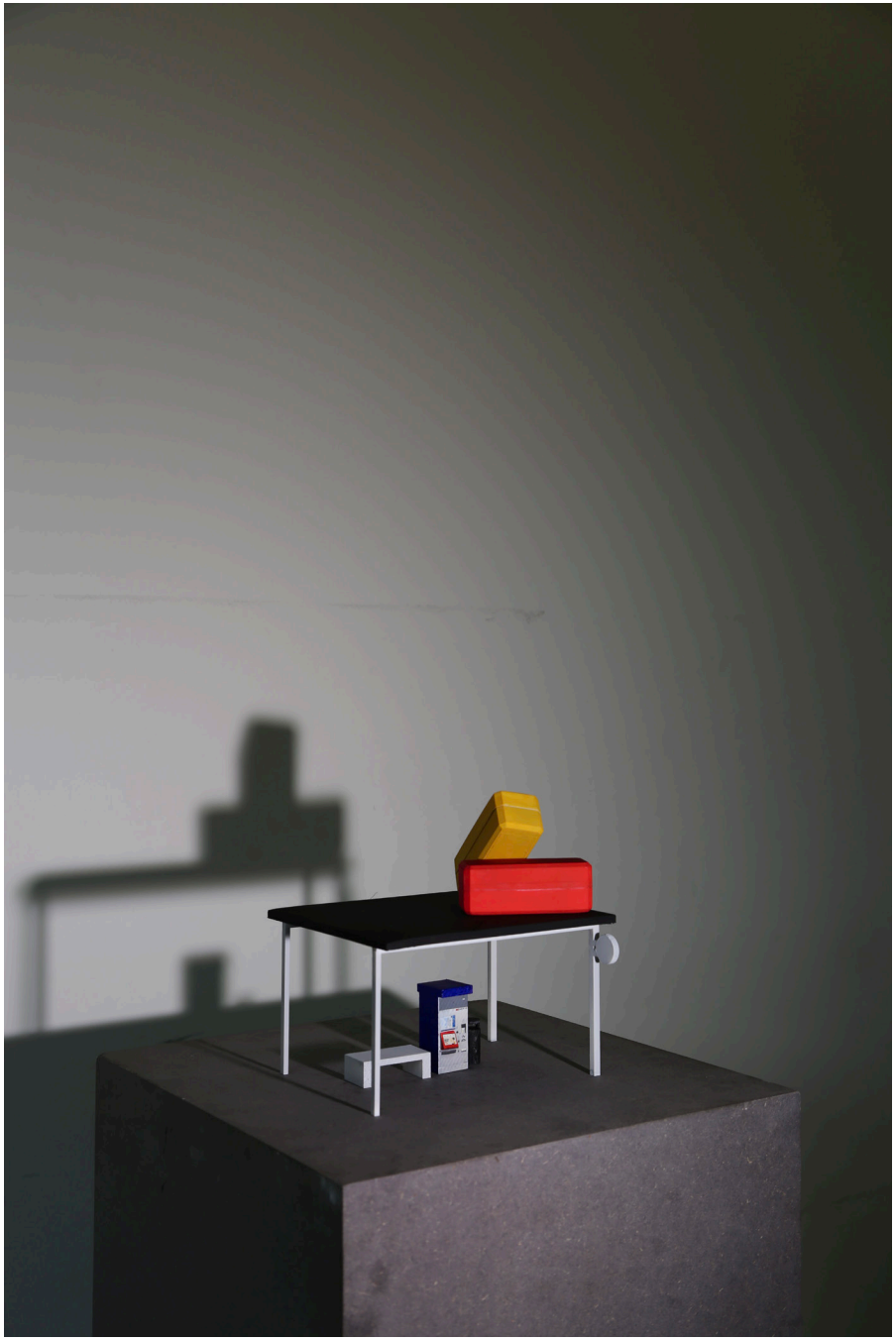
We were there, differently

This project presents a pair of small magnetic objects shared between two people during their final moments together before separation. The interaction is intentionally simple: while talking, they casually connect and move the objects in their hands, letting the magnets guide natural and satisfying movements.

The objects act as a quiet third presence. They do not record speech or capture specific content. Instead, they observe how the objects are used, how often they are touched, how long they are held, and how interaction changes over time. The system treats these patterns of interaction as a form of memory.

After goodbye, each person keeps one object. Over time, its behavior slowly changes, reflecting how shared moments transform once distance begins. The response of the object fades, becomes unstable, or tries to attract attention, depending on how it is used. The system does not react instantly, but interprets interaction over time, creating the impression that the object understands the relationship.

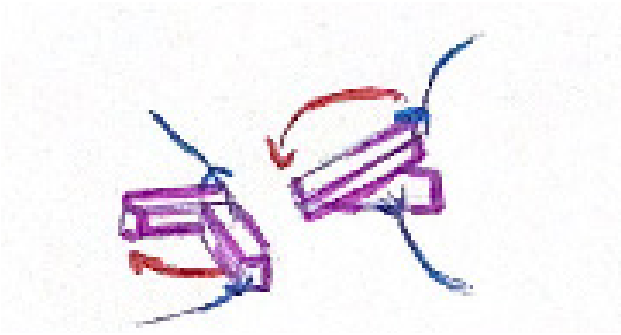
The object can be reactivated through use, but it cannot fully return to its original state alone. To restore it completely, the two objects must meet again and be played with together. In the installation version, the distance between the objects can also influence their behavior, allowing separation and reunion to become visible through changes in light, magnet strength, and feedback. In this way, the objects do not store memories, but continuously recreate them through interaction.



User Journey

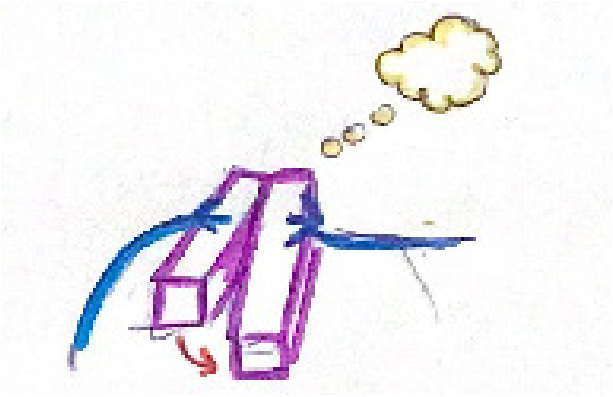
1. Two people meet and take out their pair of objects

2. Play with the object
snap, rotate, repel, etc... breathing-like light



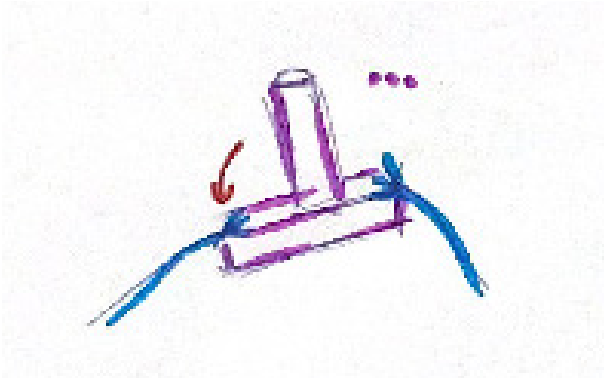
3. They stop playing and separate, each keeps their own object.

4. Each user plays with the object whenever they want, AI studies user's behavior, when and how much the user plays with it

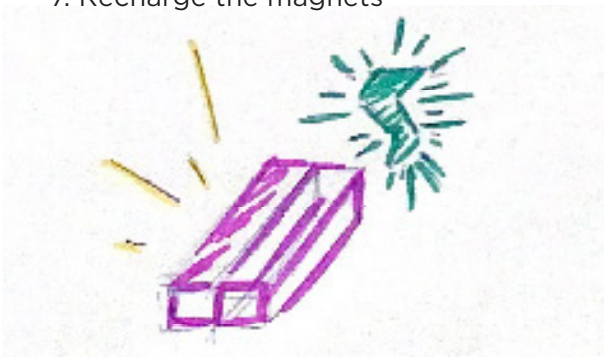


5. Based on person's routine, AI tries to attract their attention to play, light rapid blinking magnets' strength starts to fade by the time

6. By playing, the dying/fading process of the magnets become slower



7. Recharge the magnets



Context research

This project begins with the idea of distance and memory. When people are physically apart, especially when living abroad, relationships are often sustained through what we remember rather than what we share in the present. Human memory is not exact or stable; even shared moments are remembered differently by each person. We also considered the idea of chosen family, where strong emotional bonds define belonging beyond blood or legal ties. From this perspective, we explore how distance slowly reshapes what once felt like a shared experience.

AI as a subtle social mediator: here, artificial intelligence doesn't just provide information, it directs and shapes a shared human experience (a dinner) without dominating.

Be My Guest!
A Dinner Event
Hosted by Artificial
Intelligence
MIT MEDIA LAB

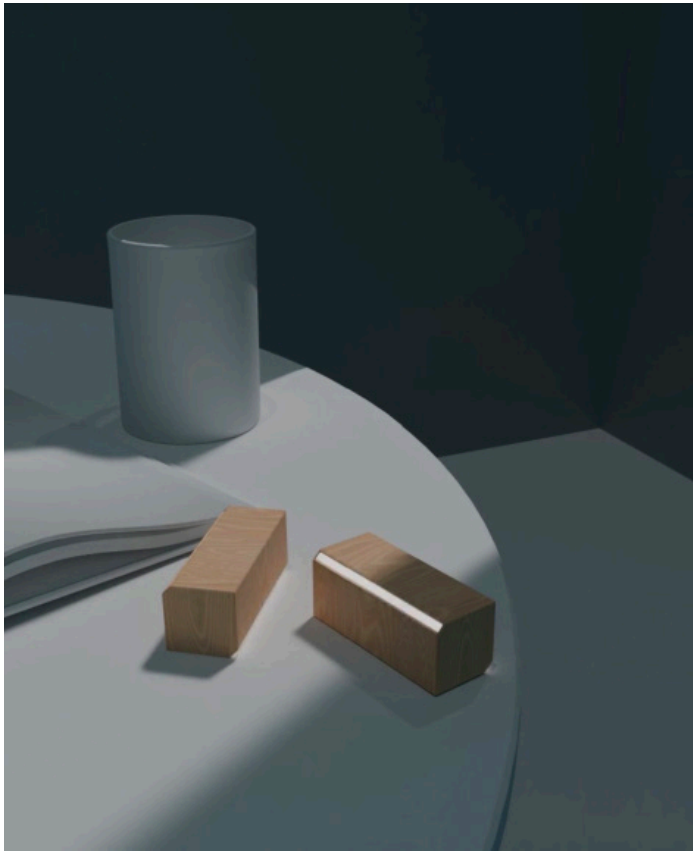
An exploration of how situations themselves can function as artworks. It focuses on context, participation, and relational dynamics rather than on a fixed object as the main artistic outcome.

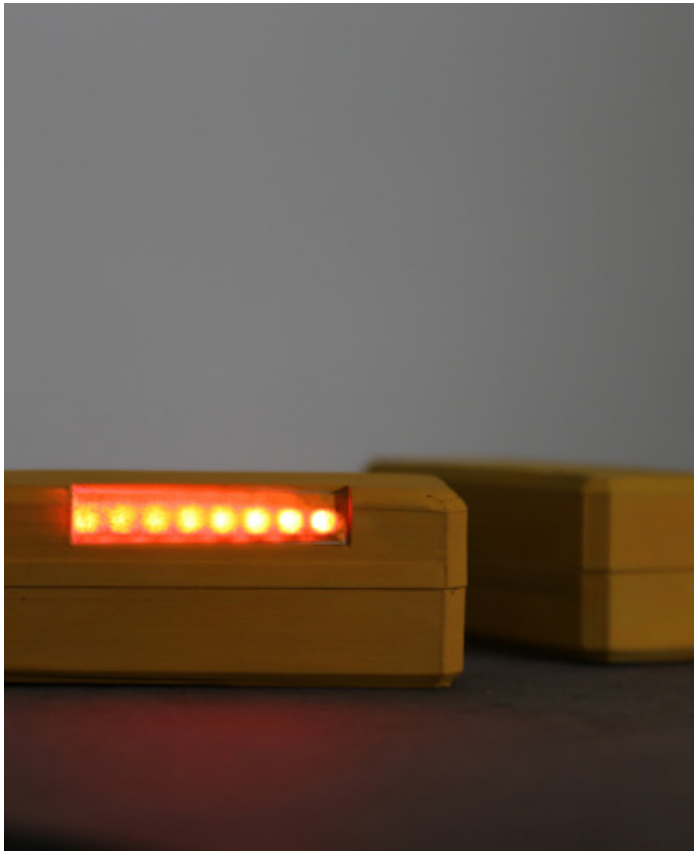
It Is What It Is
Jeremy Deller

This text discusses how forgetting is part of how memory works, not a flaw. It challenges the idea of perfect recall and highlights the role of absence, loss, and transformation in memory

To grow, we must
forget... but now
AI remembers
everything

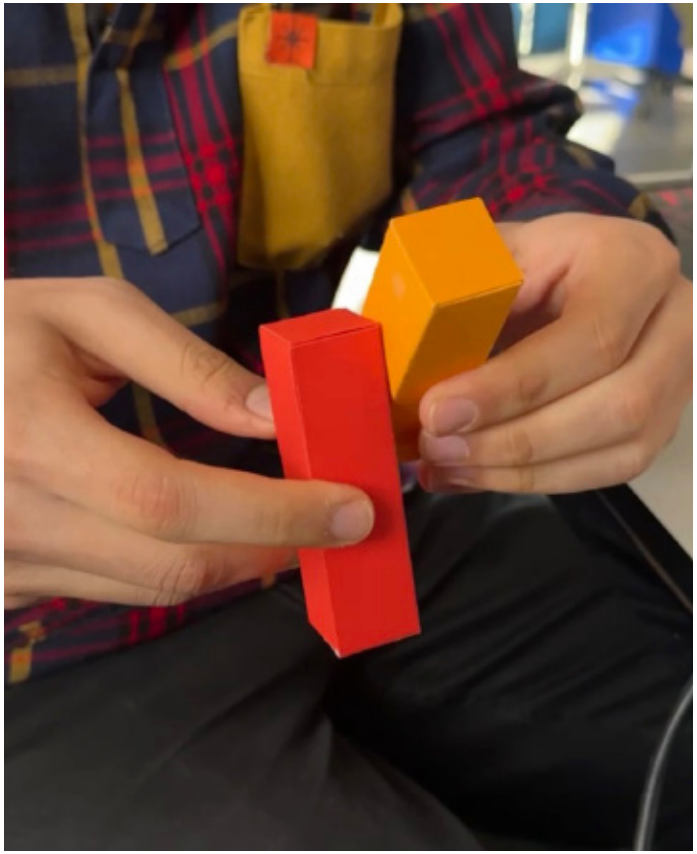
The Interface - Key visuals

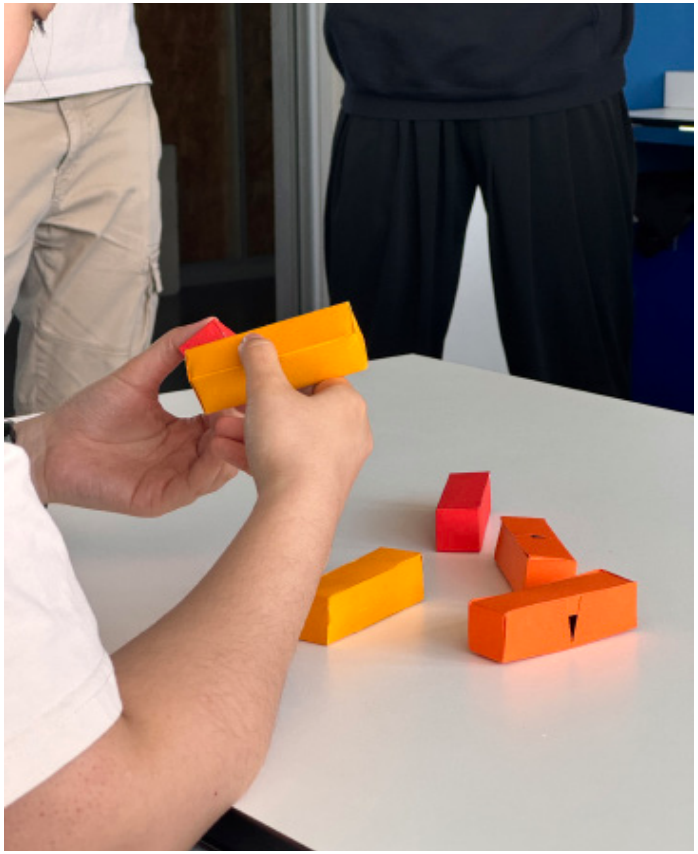


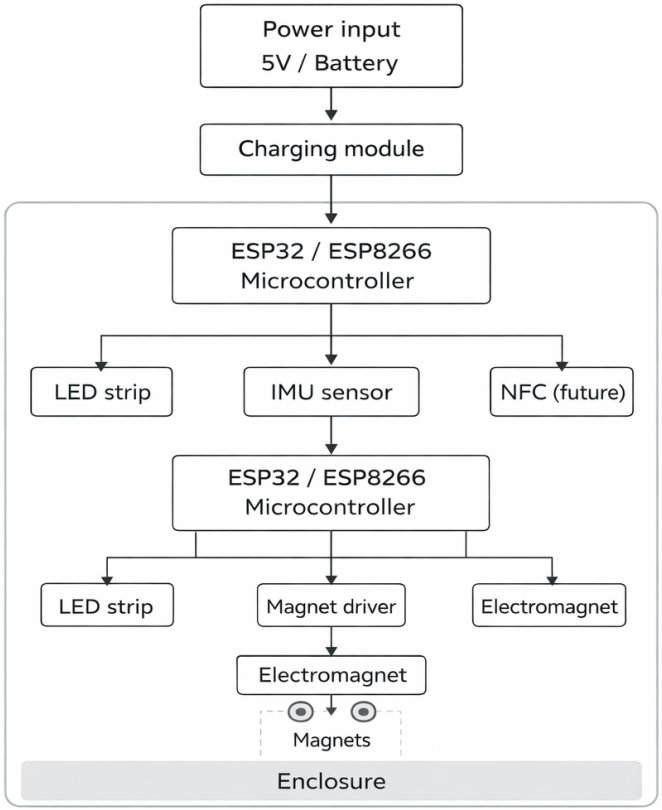
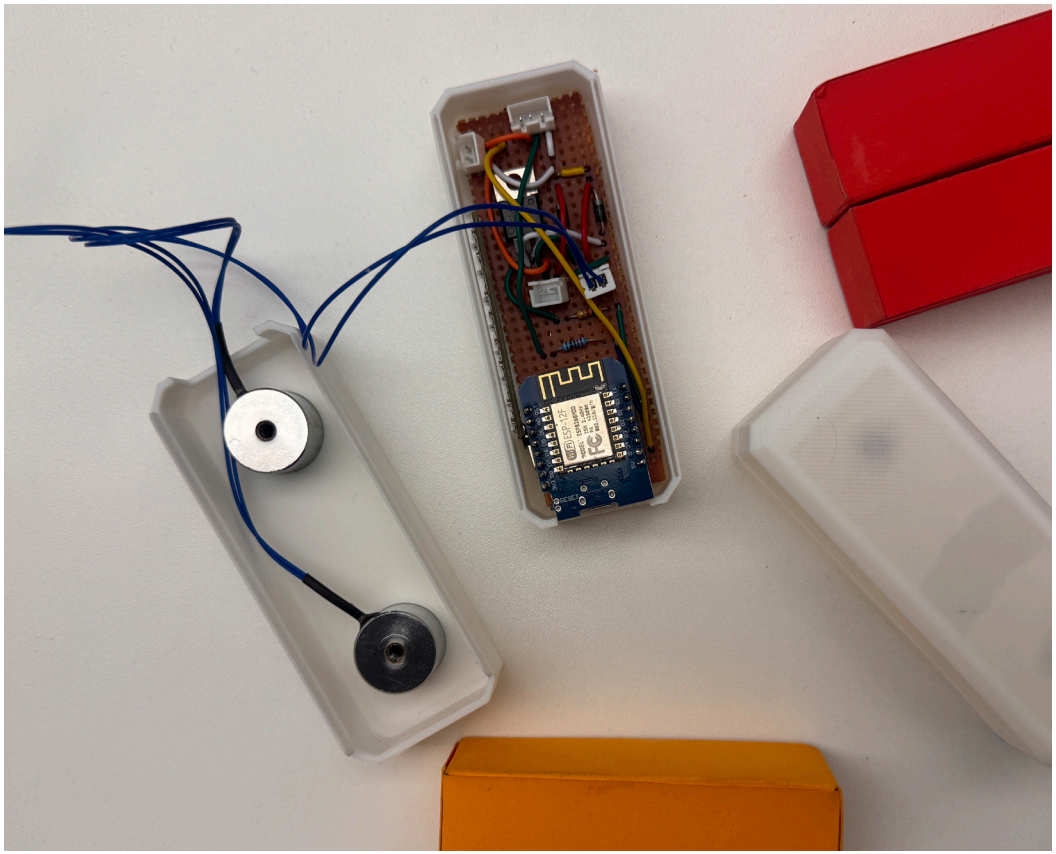


User Tests

The objects were given to two users without any explanation to observe how they would naturally interact with them. While they explored different ways of playing (even using them like a small game similar to Jenga), the three colored lights confused them and they expressed a strong need for more context to understand the purpose of the objects.





Technical diagram

- ESP32 development board
- IMU sensor
- LED strip/LEDs
- Battery
- Charging module
- Magnets (strength is managable)
- Wood
- 3D-printed structure